When the Journey Is the Destination

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Traversing the length of India, from its southernmost tropical tip to icy Kashmir in the north, the Bharat Jodo Yatra was a massive foot march against India's growing culture of intolerance. This journey to bring India together was the largest mass contact programme the country has seen in recent times. Led by Rahul Gandhi, the Yatra covered almost 4,000 kilometres, with people walking 20 to 25 kilometres every day. Hundreds of others drawn from the Indian National Congress, members of a wide range of civil society groups and some brave celebrities, filmmakers and journalists joined in solidarity with the message of the Yatra. They did so despite knowing that joining the Yatra could have negative consequences for their careers. And finally, thousands of people lined the Yatra's route, both to catch a glimpse of the famous politician and to show support.

Anyone could join the Bharat Jodo Yatra, and I did so on 15 and 16 December 2022, on the back of a research trip to India. As a committed Indian citizen, I found it hard to stay away from such a big event that was filled with positivity and hope to counter the atmosphere of hate and violence that consumes my wondrous country. As a political anthropologist interested in Indian democracy, I had to be there in person, for my discipline generates knowledge through the encounter between the self and the world. As a sister, I also wanted to show solidarity with Yogendra Yadav, my brother-in-law, who has been an acerbic critic of the Congress in the past, but who chose to walk the whole way because he believes in the message and convened a squad of civil society organizations, who are doing the same. After following social media posts on the Yatra for three months,